rising by 385.2 per cent since the last policy meet in June, though recent reports suggest that prices in the retail market have begun to come down. Onion prices rose by 24 per cent, potatoes and tur daal were 15 per cent and 10.3 per cent more expensive, respectively. Rice prices, meanwhile, rose 5 per cent. It follows then that 61.9 per cent of the respondents in the latest MOTN survey say their current expenses have become difficult to manage, compared to 59.9 per cent in the January iteration. In fact, with the persisting inflation, the response has been similar in the past four surveys, with just 7.8 per cent in the present survey saying their current expenses have gone down. Another 27.3 per cent say their expenses have gone up, but are still manageable.

81%

OF THE RESPONDENTS IN THE 18-24 AGE GROUP SAID THAT THE UNEMPLOYMENT SITUATION IN THE COUNTRY IS SERIOUS/ VERY SERIOUS

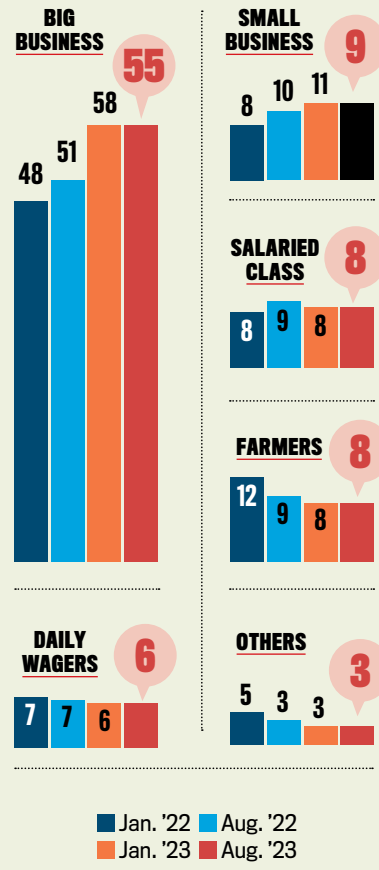
GRIM JOBS TIDINGS

While most of the hiring has happened in the services sector, jobs in manufacturing have been scarce, while agriculture remains at the mercy of the vagaries of the weather gods. This reflects clearly in the MOTN survey, where 55.5 per cent of those polled felt that the unemployment situation in the country has reached serious proportion. This was up from 53.6 per cent in the January poll. Another 16.4 per cent feel the unemployment situation was somewhat serious. But again, for India to create the number of jobs that can accommodate the millions who enter the job market every year, the economy needs to grow at a faster clip, say over 7 to 8 per cent for a few years together. That does not seem likely, for now. The general disillusionment on the jobs front is reflected in the percentage of those who say the Modi government has failed to generate employment at all—34.3 per cent—compared to 30.3 per cent who felt the government has been able to create jobs.

Adding to this pessimism is the perception that the private sector, especially big business, is reaping most of the benefit of government policies. As many as 55.4 per cent think big business has been the chief beneficiary of the NDA government's policies, down from 57.7 per cent in January, but significantly more than the August 2022 and January 2022 surveys. This indicates that the allegations of crony capitalism concerning the Adani Group the Opposition, led by the Congress, levelled against the Modi regime strike a chord with the masses, and that may not be good news for the ruling dispensation.

The latest MOTN makes one thing crystal clear. It may be good to showcase India as a shining example of growth while most economies are going through a slow phase, but that does not really count for the man on the street, who is more concerned about his livelihood and meeting his day-to-day expenses. The survey shows that the government has two tasks to manage in the run-up to the 2024 general election—high inflation and the lack of jobs. It would do well to use all the resources at its disposal to address them on a war footing. ■

Q. Who has benefitted the most from the NDA government's economic policies?



Allegations of crony capitalism still strike a chord with the masses

All figures in % and rounded off; rest, others & DK/ CS